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Job insecurity and survivor workplace behavior following COVID-19 layoff

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to investigate the impact of job insecurity (JI) on employee work performance (WP) and service innovation behavior (SIB). It further examines the mediating role of affective commitment (AC) and the moderating role of organizational cynicism and financial job dependence (FJD).

Design/methodology/approach – By using a three-wave approach, the hypotheses were tested by collecting data from 473 full-time employees and their supervisors in the Thai hotel industry.

Findings – The results demonstrated that JI negatively affected WP and SIB. AC mediated these relationships. FJD moderated these relationships such that at high levels of job dependence, the negative relationships were weaker.

Research limitations/implications – Human resource managers may reduce the negative effects of JI by creating a supportive and caring work environment through open communication. They may communicate openly with employees about the challenges the organization is facing, and involve them in planning, decision-making and implementation to mitigate the negative effects of JI. They may also provide training and development opportunities to help employees build their skills and increase their value to the organization.

Originality/value – Research on the behavioral consequences of JI is scant in the hospitality sector. Drawing on job–demand resource theory, this study attempts to fill this gap.

Keywords Job insecurity, Affective commitment, Work performance, Service innovation behavior, Organizational cynicism, Job dependence

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

Innovation is essential for business resilience and allows businesses to maintain a competitive advantage. In the hospitality industry, continuous service innovation is the key to establishing differentiation and retaining customers. Innovative service contributes to improved service quality, helps to meet customers' unique service demands and increases customer satisfaction (Yang *et al.*, 2021). They defined service innovation behavior (SIB) as the generation and promotion of new and useful service ideas by employees, aimed at enhancing service quality. Employees' innovative behavior contributes significantly to service firms' performance and long-term survival (Li and Hsu, 2016). Several studies have documented the positive outcomes associated with employees' innovative behavior as well as the factors that positively influence

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innovative behavior in the hospitality industry (Yang *et al.*, 2021). There are, however, few studies that have explored the factors that hinder innovative behaviors (Lori *et al.*, 2003). Research suggests that it is equally important to identify the negative factors in the workplace that stifle innovative behavior (Li and Li, 2022). Accordingly, scholars have called for further studies on the job stressors that prevent innovative behavior. This study examines the impact of job insecurity (JI), as a job stressor, on SIB. Li and Li (2022) noted that the relationship between JI and innovative behavior is not clear, and there is no consensus on how they are related. Therefore, it is necessary to explore the relationship between them from a variety of perspectives to fully understand it.

It is important to understand the relationship between JI and SIB for various reasons. JI, defined as the perceived threat of losing one's job (De Witte, 1999), is becoming increasingly inescapable, through rapid changes in the organizational environment and increasing non-standard employment arrangements. Furthermore, in the hospitality industry, the accelerating pace of organizational change, increasing competitive pressures and the increase in mergers and acquisitions have forced organizations to improve effectiveness and streamline operations through downsizing, outsourcing and restructuring. These actions are often associated with workforce reduction, and at the employee level, these changes create the feeling of JI (De Cuyper *et al.*, 2020; Karatepe *et al.*, 2022). Additionally, several past studies have documented that JI is one of the most powerful stressors closely associated with the hospitality industry (Etehadi and Karatepe, 2019; Xiao *et al.*, 2022). This condition has been further aggravated by the COVID-19 pandemic and economic turmoil, as the hospitality industry is particularly vulnerable to shocks such as an epidemic outbreak (Pillai *et al.*, 2021). Considering this context of uncertainty, understanding employee perceptions of JI and how those perceptions impact SIB, is important. Moreover, past studies have explored the link between JI and work performance (WP), and have found inconsistent results (Shoss, 2017; Sverke *et al.*, 2019). As WP is a key concern for managers, obtaining a better knowledge of the JI–performance link can aid organizations in better managing stress reactions and supporting organizational success. Consequently, Nikolova *et al.* (2022) called for further research investigating the impact of JI on different types of performances that have important strategic implications for organizations. Therefore, to have a complete account of employee performance, this study examines the relationship between JI and WP ("in-role" performance) and SIB ("extra-role" performance).

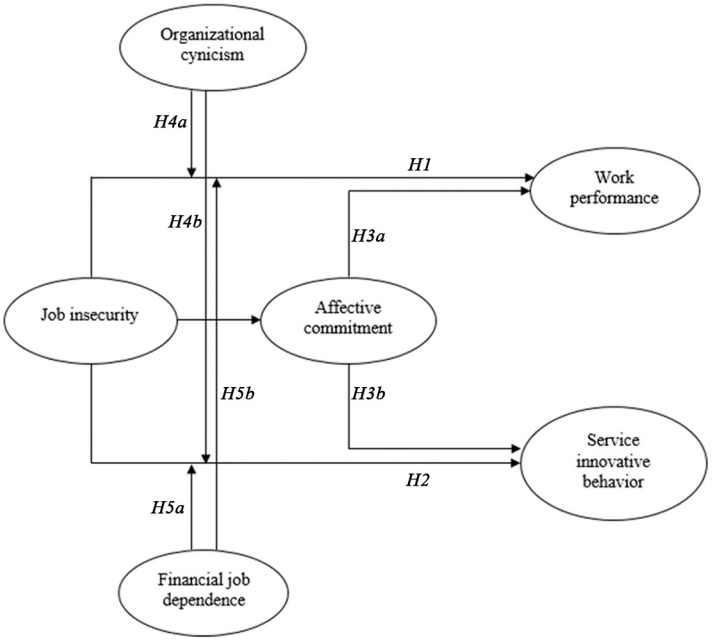
Additionally, there is also a lack of knowledge on *why* JI may have negative effects on work outcomes and *when* these negative effects are mitigated or strengthened. In particular, Xiao *et al.* (2022) called for further research on JI and the emotions that accompany it. Therefore, this study also examines the psychological mechanism underlying performance responses to JI. Xiao *et al.* (2022) have also emphasized the identification of potential moderators that affect JI and individual reactions to that insecurity. JI and the outcomes it manifest may be moderated by situational factors such as "financial job dependence (FJD)," which is caused by a lack of employability and economic need. A high rate of unemployment in Thailand may promote job dependency under conditions of low unemployment benefits, and high cultural value attached to job security (Haldorai *et al.*, 2020). Employees who are financially dependent on their jobs may continue to exhibit high levels of performance to secure their jobs in comparison to those who are less financially dependent on their jobs. However, to date, there are only two studies focusing on the moderating role of job dependence (Richter *et al.*, 2014; Sora *et al.*, 2010). Similarly, Aslam *et al.* (2016) noted that employees are more prone to express anger, antagonism and cynicism toward their organization when they sense a psychological contract violation created by danger to their job security. They noted that studies examining the moderating role of organizational

cynicism (OC) in the context of organizational change and JI are rare. In sum, this study examines whether JI impairs job performance, why and for whom as shown in Figure 1.

2. Theoretical background and hypotheses

2.1 Job Demands–Resources theory

The core premise of the Job Demands–Resources (JD-R) model (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001) is that working conditions, which are unique to each occupation, can be characterized as either job demands or job resources (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007). As a result, the JD-R model may be used in a variety of organizational contexts to investigate the effects of distinct work environments on employee work outcomes. Job demands are the physical, psychological, social or organizational components of a job that need constant physical or mental effort and are linked to physiological and psychological consequences (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). On the other hand, job resources are the physical, psychological, social and organizational characteristics of the job that can favorably help the attainment of work goals, reduce job demands or encourage personal growth and development (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). JD-R is a promising framework for investigating the impact of JI on individual and organizational outcomes (Darvishmotevali *et al.*, 2017; Karatepe *et al.*, 2022). Despite the fact that the JD-R model has been used to describe a wide range of organizational phenomena, research has yet to completely integrate JI literature into this model. JI as a form of job demand and stressor can interfere with employee work outcomes. The resources used to deal with the job demands associated with JI might be psychological, such as boosting affective commitment (AC) to lower cynicism toward the organization.



Source: Author's work

Figure 1.
Proposed framework

2.2 Job insecurity and work performance

JI is a threat to employees because it indicates the possibility of an involuntary shift in employment that can happen in both secure and insecure organizations (Darvishmotevali *et al.*, 2017; Karatepe *et al.*, 2022). Hellgren *et al.* (1999) suggested "qualitative" and "quantitative" aspects of JI. "Qualitative JI" refers to perceived threats to the value-added aspects of the job (e.g. deteriorating job conditions, limited opportunities to advance). "Quantitative JI" refers to concerns about losing one's job and its valued features (e.g. loss of insurance, wage reduction). Both aspects of JI affect employee attitudes and behavior. Our study investigates the outcomes of JI from a quantitative perspective. In general, WP refers to how well an employee performs his/her task, role, job or responsibility. WP includes two interplaying components, namely, "task performance" and "contextual performance." "Task performance" refers to an employee's core job responsibilities. It is also called "in-role prescribed behavior" (Koopmans *et al.*, 2011), and it is evident in work outcomes and deliverables, along with the quality and quantity the employee provides. "Contextual performance," also known as "discretionary extra-role behavior" (Koopmans *et al.*, 2011), transcends formal job responsibilities and includes activities such as coaching co-workers, building organizational social networks and going above and beyond the call of duty. In this study, WP is operationalized as task performance.

Based on the JD-R framework, job demands predict negative work strain in the workplace (Bakker and Demerouti, 2007). Job demands are those aspects of the job that cause strain (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). Job demands can be classified as "challenge" demands or "hindrance" demands (Cavanaugh *et al.*, 2000). Despite their energy-depleting nature, "challenge" demands are conducive to achieving goals and developing personal skills (e.g. cognitive demands), whereas "hindrance" demands are those that prevent employees from achieving their goals (e.g. JI) (Haldorai *et al.*, 2022). JI is considered a "hindrance" demand because it creates uncertainty (De Witte, 1999), and it will continue to deplete employees' physical and psychological resources as long as the sources of uncertainty persist (Demerouti *et al.*, 2001). Researchers who assert that JI has a negative effect on behavioral outcomes consider JI to be a hindrance stressor that drives undesirable behavior (Darvishmotevali *et al.*, 2017; Nikolova *et al.*, 2022). To emotionally cope with such stressors, individuals tend to behaviorally withdraw from these situations. Behavioral withdrawal can manifest as reduced "in-role" and "extra-role" performance in the workplace. For instance, Shin and Hur (2021) found that JI negatively impacted work outcomes. Consistent with these studies, and adopting the JD-R lens, we propose the following:

H1. "JI negatively affects WP."

2.3 Job insecurity and service innovation behavior

Innovative behavior is defined as the "deliberate adoption of new and improved ideas, processes, practices, and policies aimed at increasing organizational effectiveness, achieving business success, and ensuring long-term sustainability" (Anderson *et al.*, 2014, p. 1320). The study by Amabile and Conti (1999) on the impacts of downsizing on employee creativity is the earliest research investigating factors related to JI and employee innovative behavior. They observed that organizational downsizing significantly deteriorated innovative behavior among employees. Probst *et al.* (2007) investigated the direct association between JI and creativity through a series of field and laboratory investigations. They found that the study participants who had been manipulated with layoff threats were poor at the "Duncker creative problem-solving task" when compared with their control-group (no-layoff) peers. When replicating these direct relationships, Niesen *et al.* (2018) and Van Hootegem *et al.* (2019) found comparable

results. These results imply that employees who fear losing their jobs are unable to commit their time and energy to developing and implementing creative ideas in service operations. Furthermore, Etehadi and Karatepe (2019) showed that JI negatively influences SIB among hospitality employees. Hence, it is hypothesized that:

H2. "JI negatively impacts SIB."

2.4 Mediating role of affective commitment

AC reflects an employee's loyalty to his/her organization. Affectively committed employees are motivated by a strong sense of belongingness and identification that boosts their willingness to be involved in the organization's activities and accomplish the organization's goals, as well as their desire to remain with the organization (Meyer *et al.*, 2002). From the JD-R perspective, employee resources are threatened by the loss of employment, income and status as a result of JI. When employees face the threat of potential job loss, it results in a negative attitude toward supervisors, the organization and the work itself (Jiang *et al.*, 2019). Individuals who experience JI are less likely to feel a sense of belongingness and obligation to the organization. Sverke *et al.* (2002) contended that JI is a stressor that is negatively related to commitment. When the potential survival of an employee is uncertain, he/she is more likely to question the extent to which the organization will continue to value their contribution (Kong *et al.*, 2021). These perceptions lower their AC toward their organization. On the other hand, AC is a critical precursor to both "in-role" and "extra-role" behaviors (Meyer *et al.*, 2002). In agreement with this view, studies have established a link between AC and WP (Sharma and Dhar, 2016). Affectively committed employees display innovative work behavior by taking risks, and they thrive on the challenge to give aid to their organizations (Bak, 2020). Specifically, Kong *et al.* (2021) found that committed employees go the extra mile to come up with innovative service ideas to promote organizational competitiveness in the hospitality industry. Taken together, JI is negatively related to WP and SIB through lowered AC. Hence, it is hypothesized as follows:

H3. "AC mediates the relationship between JI and (a) WP and (b) SIB."

2.5 Moderating role of organizational cynicism

Cynicism, in its simplest form, is detesting and distrusting others. OC occurs when employees perceive that their organization lacks integrity, is evasive and cannot be trusted to keep its promises. Dean *et al.* (1998, p. 345) defined OC as "a negative attitude toward one's employing organization, comprised of three dimensions: a belief that the organization lacks integrity; negative affect toward the organization; and tendencies to disparaging and critical behaviors toward the organization that are consistent with these beliefs and affect." Taking these three dimensions together, OC essentially occurs as a complex attitude anchored in employee "cognitions, emotions, and behavioral" tendencies concerning the organization's lack of integrity. Sometimes, cynicism may arise as a result of repeated moral contract transgressions and in other cases a single episode may be sufficient to develop a cynical attitude. Dean *et al.* (1998) further noted that, once developed, cynicism may be brandished against top management, supervisors, patrons, colleagues and the organization as a whole.

JI has a strong negative impact on WP and SIB for employees who are highly cynical. That is, employees who are highly cynical compared to their counterparts believe that they are in an organization that is facing serious problems that will not be resolved because of self-centered

decision-makers, obstinate managers and uncooperative employees (Jiang *et al.*, 2019). As a result, highly cynical employees are suspicious of the intent, acts and values of the organization and its members. Moreover, they feel frustrated, hopeless, disillusioned, contemptuous, distressed, disgusted, angry and even ashamed when thinking about their organization (Collins, 2017). As a consequence of these negative cognitions and affective experiences, JI is more likely to have a negative impact on WP and SIB for highly cynical employees, as this is consistent with their cynical attitudes. In contrast, the negative impact of JI on WP and SIB may be less obvious among low-cynicism employees, who believe that their organization is genuine, honest, trustworthy, supportive and cooperative (Neves, 2012). As a result of these positive cognitions, low-cynicism employees are less likely to display reduced WP and reduced SIB when experiencing JI, as this contradicts their relatively positive perceptions of the organization. Furthermore, employees with a highly cynical attitude remain vigilant, scanning the organization for signs of hypocrisy and potential threat (Collins, 2017). Having a highly cynical attitude can cloud the lens through which employees see their workplace. Hence, highly cynical employees may regard layoffs as being unfair, leading to retaliation in various forms including lowering their work effort and innovative behavior. On the other hand, employees less inclined to cynicism will be less distrustful of events that occur in their workplace. These employees are better able to understand the challenges their organization is facing and may consider JI at face value, and thus these employees may not reduce their in-role performance and innovative behavior. Furthermore, job security is considered an important obligation that employees believe their organization should fulfil (Shoss, 2017). When they are dissatisfied with the level of job security, highly cynical individuals believe that their organization has failed to live up to the obligations it has to its employees. Highly cynical employees who experience JI become suspicious of the organization and its objectives and are more likely to display lower performance and innovative behavior compared to low cynicism employees. Research suggests that employees reporting higher levels of OC are unlikely to exceed the bare minimum of performance when experiencing any kind of uncertainty and mistreatment from their organization (Neves, 2012). The highly cynical also display minimal levels of innovative behavior because of distrust in their organization's decisions and actions (Aslam *et al.*, 2016). Therefore, we hypothesize as follows:

H4. "OC moderates the negative relationship between JI and (a) WP and (b) SIB, such that the relationship is stronger among employees with a high OC compared to those with a low OC."

2.6 Moderating role of financial job dependence

Despite previous research findings demonstrating that JI negatively impacts employee work attitudes and behavior, some aspects of this relationship remain unclear. A meta-analysis by Sverke *et al.* (2002) revealed inconsistent findings across previous studies. They noted that the findings of the studies differed greatly in relation to JI and its consequences. In light of these inconsistencies, Sverke *et al.* (2002) concluded that other factors may have a role in the link between JI and its consequences. Xiao *et al.* (2022) posited that individual differences might moderate the link between JI and individual reactions. Additionally, situational variables might also affect whether JI is perceived as a more or less serious threat, and that in turn could influence the severity of the consequences. In this case, the FJD of employees in their current job can be viewed as a situational variable that can have a moderating effect.

FJD refers to reliance on a job because of the resources the job offers to an individual (e.g. salary). Reactions to JI are largely determined by job dependency (Richter *et al.*, 2014; Sora *et al.*, 2010). The threats posed by JI are exacerbated at high levels of income insecurity

(Chua *et al.*, 2022). From a job preservation motivation perspective (Shoss, 2017), those employees who are economically vulnerable or have a high dependence on their job for financial security (i.e. high FJD) are inclined to protect their employment because they believe it will be more difficult to replace the job and/or income if it is lost. That is, individuals who are economically insecure, or those individuals who believe they will not be able to meet their living expenses if they lose their current job, take active measures to prevent job loss. As an active job preservation strategy, employees try to portray themselves as an ideal employee by enhancing their task performance and extra-role performance. Economically insecure employees believe that their heightened performance will improve their chance of continued employment when experiencing JI (Brockner *et al.*, 1987). These employees also use persuasive strategies, like getting involved in extra-role behavior, such as innovative behavior, to draw attention to their abilities, as they believe extra-role performance is instrumental in securing one's job. Taking these assertions together with a job preservation motivation perspective (Shoss, 2017), we believe that the detrimental effects of JI on WP and SIB are less prominent among employees with higher FJD than those with lower FJD. For instance, Richter *et al.* (2014) found that the experience of high job dependence did not exacerbate the negative association between JI and work attitude (job satisfaction). On the other hand, employees with low job dependence reacted more negatively to JI. Similarly, Sora *et al.* (2010) showed that for employees with income security and thus reduced economic vulnerabilities (reflecting low FJD), the negative association between JI and job attitudes was stronger than their counterparts who had no access to these benefits. Therefore, we hypothesize as follows:

H5. "The negative impact of JI on (a) WP and (b) SIB is moderated by FJD such that the negative relationship is stronger for those with low FJD rather than high FJD."

3. Methodology

3.1 Samples and procedure

The study participants included full-time Thai hotel service employees who survived COVID-19 layoffs and their supervisors. First, one of the research team members contacted the human resource (HR) managers of the hotels in Phuket to explain the study's goal. Out of the 35 contacted hotels, 18 hotels consented to take part in our study. Out of those 18 hotels, 8 were classified as luxury hotels, 7 were upscale and 3 were mid-scale hotels. With the help of the HR managers, one of the study team members personally visited each property to distribute the survey packets to the diverse spectrum of employees who consented to participate. We invited only those service employees who had survived COVID-19 layoffs. We distributed 40 survey packets to each of the 8 luxury hotels, 30 to each of the 7 upscale hotels, and 20 survey packets to each of the 3 mid-scale hotels. In sum, we distributed 590 survey packets. The survey packets included the survey instrument, the survey completion procedure, information on the anonymity and confidentiality of the responses and a self-adhesive return envelope. On completion, the surveys were placed in the return envelopes and the respondents were instructed to drop them into the locked drop boxes that were placed near the reception desk at each property.

We conducted the study in three waves by collecting data from the employees during the first-wave (T1) and the second-wave (T2) and from their supervisors during the third-wave (T3). At T1, the employees provided the responses for JI (independent variable), their background information and their psychological attachment with a laid-off victim. At T2, data was collected for the mediator (AC) and the moderators (OC and FJD), and at T3 the supervisors rated their employees' WP and SIB. The data was collected during September–November 2020 (T1), January–March 2021 (T2) and May–July 2021 (T3). We received 261

surveys from luxury hotels, 170 from upscale hotels and 58 from mid-scale hotels. Out of the 489 surveys, 481 surveys were usable from T1. During T2, we approached these 481 employees, and, after matching the T1 and T2 responses, 476 responses were usable. At T3, questionnaires were distributed to the supervisors of these 476 employees. After matching the responses, 473 usable responses were recorded. Attrition bias occurs "if participants who stay in a study differ from those who drop out" (Gustavson *et al.*, 2012, p. 1). As only a few respondents dropped out from the subsequent waves, following Gustavson *et al.* (2012), we requested that the supervisors examine the characteristics of participants and non-participants in the subsequent surveys. The supervisors stated that the participants and non-participants were demographically similar. Of the 473 participants with a mean age of 37 years, 30% are male and 70% are female. The mean experience in the current hotel and the hotel industry was 7.5 and 14 years, respectively. Regarding their education, 70% of the respondents had earned a four-year degree, 26% had a two-year degree and 4% had a master's degree. Regarding department affiliation, 32% belonged to the front office, 38% were from food and beverage and 30% were from housekeeping.

3.2 Measures

Multi-items from previous similar research were used to measure all constructs. A higher score reflects a higher level of each construct. A back-translation was used to translate measurements originally in English into Thai. Prior to initiating the data collection procedure, two pilot samples of ten employees were used to test the employee surveys (T1 and T2). The supervisor survey was pretested with the assistance of five supervisors. The participants reported no difficulty in reading and understanding the items, so no amendments were necessary. The respondents responded on a five-point scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree) for all constructs except psychological attachment with a laid-off victim.

JI was measured with a three-item scale from Hellgren *et al.*'s (1999) quantitative JI scale. AC was assessed using Meyer *et al.*'s (1993) six-item scale. Five items developed by Brandes *et al.* (2008), using the theoretical definition proposed by Dean *et al.* (1998), were used to measure OC. FJD was measured by four items developed by Richter *et al.* (2014). The seven-item job performance scale developed by Williams and Anderson (1991) was used to measure employees' overall WP. Employee SIB was measured with a six-item scale from Hu *et al.* (2009). Two items from Brockner *et al.* (1987) measured survivors' prior attachment to the layoff victims. These two items were rated on a seven-point Likert scale ranging from "not at all close" (1) to "very close" (7).

3.3 Control variables

Age, gender, tenure in the current hotel, tenure in the hotel industry, education level and hotel classification were treated as control variables to rule out potentially spurious relations (Karatepe *et al.*, 2022). Additionally, prior studies have documented that layoff survivors react more severely to layoffs, JI and downsizing when they are close or psychologically attached to the layoff victims (Brockner *et al.*, 1987). Therefore, we also collected employee responses to psychological attachment with a laid-off victim and controlled it. As the control variables did not affect the results significantly, we report the results without the control variables.

3.4 Common method bias

To control for method bias, precautions were taken during the study's design following the suggestions of Podsakoff *et al.* (2003). We obtained the measures of the independent and

outcome variables from different sources. The responses to the predictor variables were collected from the employees and the responses to the outcome variables were provided by the employees' respective supervisors. Additionally, we also created temporal separation by introducing a time lag between the measurement of the predictor and the outcome variables. Next, the participants were assured that there are no right or wrong responses and that they should be as honest as possible while answering questions. This procedure is likely to reduce respondents' evaluation apprehension and make them less likely to alter their responses to be more socially acceptable. Furthermore, using PLS the results from the full collinearity test were below 3.3, indicating the models were free of common method bias (Kock, 2015).

4. Results

4.1 Reliability and validity

As the supervisors rated the employees' WP and SIB, there is a possibility that the supervisor's rating of more than one subordinate creates a nested effect. However, the ANOVA results were not significant. Therefore, we can be conclude that the supervisors' ratings were relatively independent and did not significantly influence the study's outcomes. Hair *et al.* (2017) recommended evaluating the loadings, average variance extracted (AVE), composite reliability (CR) and Dijkstra-Henseler (ρA) to test the convergent and the discriminant validity. As displayed in Table 1, the loadings are above 0.7, AVEs are greater than 0.5 and CRs are above 0.7, thus indicating that the measures were both valid and reliable.

We used Fornell and Larcker's criterion and Heterotrait–Monotrait (HTMT) criterion to evaluate discriminant validity. Discriminant validity is established if the square root of the AVE exceeds all the correlations in the same row and column of the specific construct. The HTMT values were reported in Table 2, and all were under a 0.9 threshold, indicating evidence of discriminant validity. In sum, as portrayed in Table 2, discriminant validity of the constructs was achieved.

4.2 Hypotheses testing

Hair *et al.* (2017) recommended using a bootstrapping approach with a resample of 5,000 to examine the β values and accompanying *t*-values. The variance inflation factor (VIF) is below 5, indicating there was no problem with multicollinearity (Hair *et al.*, 2017). JI was negatively related to employees' WP ($\beta = -0.174$; $p < 0.0\ 001$, $R^2 = 0.30$). The results support *H1*. Similarly, JI was also negatively related to employees' SIB ($\beta = -0.231$; $p < 0.0\ 001$, $R^2 = 0.53$), thus supporting *H2*. These results indicate that the higher the JI, the lower the WP and SIB. These findings are in line with the findings of previous studies (Etehadi and Karatepe, 2019; Shin and Hur, 2021). To test the indirect effects, Preacher and Hayes (2008) approach was adopted to obtain the estimates and the confidence intervals (CIs). AC mediated the relationship between JI and employee WP ($\beta = -0.023$; CI: −0.046, −0.004). AC also mediated the relationship between JI and SIB ($\beta = -0.110$; CI: −0.181, −0.039). Therefore, *H3* is supported. We hypothesized that OC moderates the negative link between JI and WP and SIB. Although the interactions were significant, i.e. JI × OC on WP ($\beta = 0.133$, $p < 0.001$) and JI × OC on SIB ($\beta = 0.223$, $p < 0.001$), they were not in the expected direction. Therefore, *H4* was not supported. One plausible explanation could be that cynical survivors believe they have the necessary resources to deal effectively during times of uncertainty (Mishra and Spreitzer, 1998). They further observed that highly cynical survivors exhibit increased levels of arousal in a post-layoff environment. Brockner *et al.* (1987) confirmed that arousal stimulates the use of "effort-related" coping strategies. Therefore, when faced with JI, highly cynical survivors develop coping strategies to manage uncertainties by demonstrating increased work efforts (Brandes *et al.*, 2008). Finally, as expected, FJD moderated the negative relationship between JI

Construct	Loading	AVE	CR	Cronbach's alpha	Dijkstra-Henseler ρA	VIF
JI		0.824	0.932	0.701	0.704	2.681
JI1	0.738					
JI2	0.981					
JI3	0.985					
AC		0.559	0.884	0.783	0.785	3.142
AC1	0.765					
AC2	0.732					
AC3	0.766					
AC4	0.772					
AC5	0.709					
AC6	0.738					
OC		0.963	0.992	0.990	0.989	2.226
OC1	0.981					
OC2	0.980					
OC3	0.978					
OC4	0.994					
OC5	0.974					
FJD		0.950	0.987	0.984	0.984	2.414
FJD1	0.965					
FJD2	0.982					
FJD3	0.964					
FJD4	0.988					
WP		0.605	0.914	0.832	0.831	2.968
WP1	0.810					
WP2	0.795					
WP3	0.827					
WP4	0.746					
WP5	0.737					
WP6	0.795					
WP7	0.728					
SIB		0.600	0.900	0.825	0.826	2.338
SIB1	0.772					
SIB2	0.780					
SIB3	0.774					
SIB4	0.778					
SIB5	0.739					
SIB6	0.804					

Table 1.
Loadings and reliability

Source: Author' swork

and (a) WP ($\beta = -0.175, p < 0.001, \Delta R^2 = 0.6$) and (b) SIB ($\beta = -0.222, p < 0.001, \Delta R^2 = 1.2$). JI is more negatively related to WP when FJD is low ($\beta = -0.517, p < 0.001$) than when it is high ($\beta = 0.375, p < 0.001$). Similarly, JI is more negatively related to SIB when FJD is low ($\beta = -0.329, p < 0.001$) than when it is high ($\beta = 0.170, p < 0.001$). Thus, the results are in line with the results of Richter *et al.* (2014), supporting *H5*. To better interpret the moderation patterns of FJD, we plotted the slopes. Figures 2 and 3 show that JI was more negatively related to WP and SIB for low levels of FJD. The summary of results are shown in Table 3.

5. Discussion and conclusion

5.1 Conclusion

Under the unexpected changes caused by COVID-19, the study sought to shed light on the effects of JI on WP and SIB. The study further examined the mediating role of AC and the

moderating role of OC and FJD. From the JD-R perspective, stable employment is viewed as a valuable resource, and the threat of losing that employment has a detrimental impact on employees' work attitude and behavior. Furthermore, the results suggested that an increased perception of JI lowered AC, which in turn negatively affected employees' WP and their SIB. Finally, FJD moderated the negative relationship between JI and its outcomes. In particular, at heightened insecurity levels and with low financial dependency, employees' WP and SIB were low. The economic hardship of losing a job can be especially distressing to an employee who has high financial demands. From a job preservation motivation perspective, such employees are motivated to increase their WP and innovative behavior when such performance is, or is assumed to be, instrumental toward securing their job.

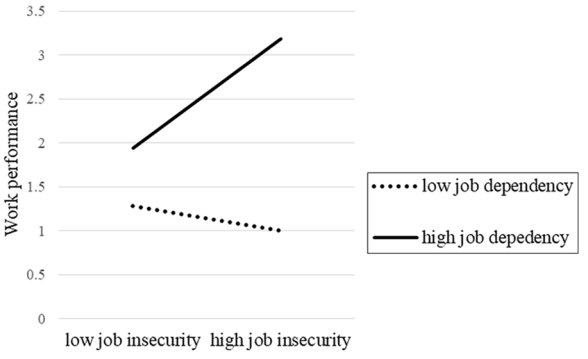
5.2 Theoretical contributions

The findings contribute significantly to the corpus of knowledge in several ways. Research on the behavioral consequences of JI in the tourism and hospitality sector has been scarce to date (Khan *et al.*, 2022). Additionally, De Cuyper *et al.* (2020) and Sverke *et al.* (2019) noted that the majority of studies on JI are from Europe or the USA and have accordingly called for further research. To address these gaps, the study investigated the impact of JI on hotel

	JI	AC	FJD	OC	SIB	WP
JI	*0.908*	*0.392*	*0.091*	*0.615*	*0.647*	*0.073*
AC	−0.280**	*0.748*	*0.045*	*0.094*	*0.035*	*0.324*
FJD	−0.042	−0.09	*0.975*	*0.057*	*0.074*	*0.401*
OC	−0.13	−0.08	0.006	*0.981*	*0.153*	*0.037*
SIB	−0.728**	0.358**	0.516**	−0.114**	*0.775*	*0.433*
WP	−0.548**	0.150**	0.130**	−0.35**	0.184**	*0.778*
Mean	3.732	2.532	2.512	3.998	3.943	3.082
SD	0.594	0.568	0.689	0.634	0.454	0.570

Notes: Values in italic are the square root of AVEs. Below the diagonals are the correlation values; Above the diagonals are HTMT values
Source: Author's work

Table 2.
Discriminant validity



Source: Author's work

Figure 2.
Moderating effect of FJD on the relationship between JI and WP

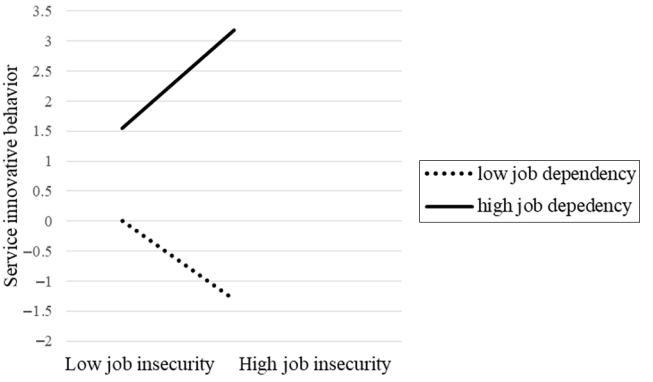


Figure 3.
Moderating effect of FJD on the relationship between JI and SIB

Source: Author's work

Hypotheses	Path coefficient	*t*-value	Result
H1: JI → WP	−0.174	−3.946**	Supported
H2: JI → SIB	−0.231	−5.209**	Supported
H3a: JI → AC → WP	−0.023	CI [−0.046, −0.004]	Supported
H3b: JI → AC → SIB	−0.110	CI [−0.181, −0.039]	
H4a: JI × OC → WP	0.133	3.841**	Not supported
H4b: JI × OC → SIB	0.223	5.147**	
H5a: JI × FJD → WP	−0.175	−3.982**	Supported
H5b: JI × FJD → SIB	−0.222	−5.038**	

Table 3.
Summary of results

Note: $^{**}p < 0.001$
Source: Author's work

employees' WP and SIB. Therefore, the study facilitated the integration of two otherwise independent research fields, JI and SIB, opening new paths for their development. The results add JI as one important antecedent to SIB. The findings contribute to JD-R theory by demonstrating that JI reduces WP and SIB. Specifically, the results revealed that all direct and indirect paths from JI to WP and SIB were negative. Consequently, our study refutes the findings of studies that claimed a positive relationship based on job preservation strategies (Shoss, 2017). This indicates that in Thailand, a country with high uncertainty avoidance, JI is seen as a stressor that is hard to overcome. This perception leads to ineffective coping strategies that further leads to lower levels of performance. This also implies that when employees experience a stressor, such as JI, they shift effort away from in-role and extra-role job behaviors to deal with it. Similarly, a stronger negative relationship between JI and SIB indicates that when employees experience stressors in the form of JI, the first behaviors to be withdrawn are those that are not part of formal job requirements (Haldorai *et al.*, 2022).

Second, studies that examine mediating constructs between JI and its outcomes have gained a substantial amount of attention. Our research responds to a call for theoretical explanations for contradictory findings on the work insecurity–performance relationship, as highlighted in recent JI reviews (De Cuyper *et al.*, 2020; Shoss, 2017). To accomplish this, we examined the mediating role of AC in the link between JI and its behavioral

outcomes. The findings add to AC literature by suggesting JI as an antecedent to AC. Furthermore, the relationship between JI and workplace behavior conforms to Ortony *et al.*'s (1988) cognitive processes theory involving the generation of emotions. The proposed research model in this study is built on an emotional trigger that flows from an employee's perception of JI. Cognitive evaluation of this perception (Ortony *et al.*, 1988) leads to an emotional reaction, such as lowered AC, that further affects work behavior.

A third key contribution of this study is the role of FJD. To examine employees working in an extreme and uncertain environment, this study was carried out in Thailand following the COVID-19 outbreak. The study results revealed the influence of employees' FJD on the relationship between JI and its consequences. Furthermore, given the high levels of volatility experienced by hotel frontline employees, this study offers a fairly rigorous examination of employees' experiences in a challenging environment (such as during COVID-19, economic crisis or natural catastrophes). The COVID-19 pandemic created a new situation, particularly for service employees (Liu-Lastres *et al.*, 2023). Such outbreaks being contagious, pose additional challenges for employees who have direct contact with customers. They involve immediate threats to frontline employees facing changing shutdown and social distancing protocols, in addition to furloughs and layoffs in workplaces. Given the catastrophic effects of the COVID-19 pandemic on frontline workers and the disruption to their daily schedules, it is critical to understand the evaluation, emotion and behavior of employees during these occurrences. Therefore, our study in the context of the workplace allowed us to ascertain the time-lag effects of employees' job stresses on their performance during COVID-19.

Methodologically, previous research on JI has heavily relied on cross-sectional designs (Probst *et al.*, 2020). These designs limit the ability to tease out the complex relationships among the constructs over the course of time. The consequences of JI due to layoffs may diminish or magnify over time due to multiple layoff events, since they alter the psychological contract of the employee. Accordingly, Probst *et al.* (2020) suggested at least three waves of data to understand how JI and work behaviors unfold over time. Additionally, Shoss (2017) called for further research on JI to truly assess the mediation mechanisms. In line with these suggestions, we conducted a three-wave study by collecting data from multiple sources to allow for more robust inferences about the mediation mechanism.

5.3 Practical implications

The findings have the following practical implications. JI will remain prevalent in organizations as long as trends toward "globalization," "restructuring," and "downsizing" continue. The hospitality industry is characterized by long working hours, high workload and shift work. It is inevitable that service employees are subject to JI. Hospitality human resource managers must accept the fact that employees appraise JI as a stressor that can severely impede employee in-role and extra-role behaviors. JI stifles innovation behavior, while the change process thrives on creative solutions and innovation behavior (De Cuyper *et al.*, 2020). Accordingly, HR managers may take suitable and constructive measures to reduce the detrimental effects of JI. Specifically, the managers should create a supportive and caring work environment through open communication (Kim and Karatepe, 2023). Prior studies have suggested that communicating the challenges that the organization is facing, and encouraging employee involvement in planning, implementation and decision-making, can mitigate the negative effects of JI even in turbulent environments (Huang *et al.*, 2012). Similarly, employees' fear of JI may be reduced by communicating future organizational goals, which is a helpful resource that promotes predictability and makes the situation more

clear (Jiang *et al.*, 2019). Employees are motivated to seek explanations regarding their job when there is uncertainty about it. As a result, individuals who have access to clear and realistic communication have more information about their future as well as more resources to cope with the negative repercussions of JI. Hotel firms' employees and supervisors may be encouraged to help other fellow employees by sharing vital work-related information and expressing care for coworkers.

Additionally, managers may involve employees in participatory decision-making, as this gives them more control over the situation, thereby reducing JI (Nikolova *et al.*, 2022). Participatory decision-making may improve the pace of information circulation across the organization and increase a sense of belongingness to an organization. When employees are supported, they may attribute JI as a factor that is completely outside of the firm's control, and therefore may uphold their performance. This may reduce employees' negative appraisal of JI. Also, to minimize the behavioral consequences of JI, hotel firms may make sure that appropriate HR practices and policies are in place, and that they are transparent and clearly explained to the employees. Furthermore, hotel firms may introduce additional paid time-off, or a work-roster system, rather than opting for layoffs of employees. This will require both employee and manager willingness, as well as cross-collaboration, to keep employees on board.

Employee attitudes, such as commitment, are the most difficult to recover fully following a layoff. Hotel firms may focus on organizational interventions that target employee commitment. Layoff survivors are most likely to search for reasons to remain committed to their firms. Dawis and Lofquist (1984) suggested "occupational reinforcers" that may assist employees during times of transition. These "reinforcers" include factors such as co-workers, social status and security, among others. By introducing interventions that make "occupational reinforcers" salient, the survivors will be better equipped to move forward in the organization. At the same time, organizations must exercise caution when dealing with employees whose performance drops during times of JI. These employees may be motivated but could be turning toward a more passive coping strategy (Koen *et al.*, 2020), which could harm their performance. Such employees may need support from their organizations to cope. One approach to achieve this is by maintaining a strong norm of fairness, as organizational justice minimizes the detrimental impacts of JI on attitudinal outcomes (Sverke *et al.*, 2002).

Our results showed that JI led to favorable outcomes for highly cynical employees. This does not imply cynicism should be fostered to capitalize on its beneficial features. Instead, cynical attitudes may be appropriately used so as to maximize their positive effects (Brandes *et al.*, 2008). Cutler (2000, p. 310) observed that, "Rather than developing a management culture which does not tolerate cynicism, it may be more expedient to find a way of tapping into the cynic's resources. Stamping him or her out is not a practical option." Therefore, organizations may encourage cynical employees to express themselves freely and challenge the current norms in ways that promote critical thinking. This may further liberate cynic employees from self-imposed pressure to accept existing practices.

5.4 Limitations and areas of further research

Insights into future research can be drawn from the limitations of this study. First, the study samples include full-time employees from the Thai hotel industry. Hence, the results cannot be generalized to other regions. Future studies may examine whether the relationship between JI and performance differs by country and if this relationship is driven by specific country-level variables (e.g. labor market policies). Second, the data was collected by adopting a three-wave

approach, and outcome variables were measured based on supervisory ratings. Future studies may benefit from using longitudinal designs and more objective measures for performance. It may also be worth investigating other behaviors with strategic consequences for firms, such as counterproductive behaviors, ethical behaviors and safety performance. Third, the present study examined the psychological mechanism to explain the relationship between JI and performance. Probst *et al.* (2020) introduced cognitive failure as a potential mediator in this relationship. Future studies may explore whether other psychological and cognitive factors affect employees' work behaviors for a more extensive understanding of the role of JI. Fourth, data on JI, AC, WP, SIB, cynicism and FJD was collected after the COVID-19 layoff transpired, and we could not compare the difference in performance between those laid-off and those retained. Future studies may include pre-layoff and post-layoff samples.

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